

Australia



Area 2,967,909 sq miles (7,686,850 km)
Population 22.6 million
Capital Canberra
Currency Australian dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 81 years



An island continent located between the Indian and Pacific oceans, the Commonwealth of Australia is the world's sixth-largest country. It has a varied landscape that includes tropical rainforests, arid deserts, snowcapped mountains, agricultural land, and magnificent beaches.



▲ SYDNEY HARBOUR

Shown here is a panoramic view of the vibrant Sydney Harbour area—on the left is the famous Sydney Opera House, which hosts cultural performances.

Some of its most famous natural features are Uluru (also known as Ayers Rock) and the Great Barrier Reef. Most Australians are descendants of immigrants from Britain, Ireland, and other European countries. Native Aborigines today make up about two percent of the population.

Papua New Guinea



Area 178,703 sq miles (462,840 sq km)
Population 7 million
Capital Port Moresby
Currency Kina
Official language English
Life expectancy 57 years



◀ CROWNED BIRD

Named after the British monarch Queen Victoria, the Victoria Crowned Pigeon is a large blue-gray pigeon with a unique white-tipped, lace-like crest. It is native to the New Guinea region.



Located on the eastern end of New Guinea Island, Papua New Guinea gained independence from Australia in 1975. It includes several other groups of islands in the North Pacific Ocean. With around 800 different languages and even more tribes, Papua New Guinea is the most linguistically diverse country in the world. The majority of the people are Christians, but local beliefs and traditions are still widely followed. Papua New Guinea is rich in minerals such as gold and copper, and its Porgera gold mine is one of the world's largest.

Micronesia



Area 271 sq miles (702 sq km)
Population 106,487
Capital Palikir (Pohnpei Island)
Currency US dollar
Official languages English
Life expectancy 68 years



Situated in the Pacific Ocean, the Federated States of Micronesia is made up of four island-cluster states: Pohnpei, Kosrae, Chuuk, and Yap. Micronesia was formerly under US rule, but became independent in 1986. It still has a strong relationship with the US—receiving preferential trading rights and considerable aid. Micronesia's economic strengths are tourism, fishing, and the production of betel nuts and copra.

Marshall Islands



Area 70 sq miles (181 sq km)
Population 68,480
Capital Majuro
Currency US dollar
Official languages English and Marshallese
Life expectancy 71 years



The Marshall Islands are made up of 34 widely scattered atolls in the central Pacific Ocean. Only 24 of these are inhabited. Most of the population live in Majuro, the capital and commercial center, and Ebeye Island. The Marshall Islands became independent from the US in 1986. However, the economy is almost entirely dependent on US aid, and rent from the US missile base on Kwajalein Atoll.



▲ ISLAND PARADISE

Many tourists travel to the Marshall Islands for the clear skies and unspoiled beaches, which are an ideal base for scuba diving and sport fishing.

